Narrated Accessibility Walk

North Cambridge to Davis Square, Somerville, MA: Shea Rd, Kingston St, the Community Path and Davis Square, by day and at night

Pilot report 3 | Recorded October 23 (day) and October 24 (night), 2026 | Public version, October 30, 2026

Prepared by Uri Kartoun, PhD, Founder, DBbun LLC, Cambridge, MA | uri.kartoun@dbbun.com | dbbun.com

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Summary

Three narrated smartphone videos documented an everyday trip on foot from Massachusetts Avenue at Shea Road in North Cambridge to Davis Square in Somerville and back, by day and at night, passing a primary care and pediatrics clinic in Davis Square. Davis station on the Red Line is the main transit link from this area to research hospitals in Cambridge and Boston. Items are possible barriers and positive features observed along the way.

- **27 items recorded:** 21 possible barriers, 6 rated high severity, plus 6 positive features.
- **The nearest station entrance has no elevator.** At Davis station's Holland St entrance there are only stairs and escalators; the street elevator is at the College Ave entrance across the square. At night the walker also found no sign at the Holland St entrance pointing to that elevator.
- **The approach is the burden, not the destination:** a dangerous uncontrolled crossing, a closed section of the Community Path with a detour onto the road, 2-inch gaps on the detour, and a brick sidewalk only about 2 ft wide.
- **Positives:** root-lifted concrete ground down on Shea Rd, a wide path with benches, flat sidewalks and curb ramps in Davis Square, and a clinic entrance with a push-button opener.
- **At night:** bright LED lighting on the Community Path, but a dark stretch on Shea Rd, glare inside the station, and an unpleasant station elevator.

Disclaimer. This report was produced with the help of AI tools (automatic speech transcription and AI-assisted image analysis; see "How this report was produced") and was reviewed by the author. Errors and omissions are possible. Items are possible barriers observed on two days, not legal compliance

determinations or findings of violation. Distances and widths are estimates. Observations reflect conditions on October 23 and 24, 2026 and may have changed since.

Walk details

Dates	October 23, 2026, midday, sunny and dry; October 24, 2026 (Saturday), evening after dark, dry
Recordings	Video 1: outbound, Massachusetts Ave at Shea Rd to Davis Square (13 min 54 s). Video 2: return, Davis Square to Shea Rd (11 min 27 s). Video 3: night walk, Shea Rd to Davis Square and into Davis station (15 min 22 s).
Route	Shea Rd (Cambridge), Kingston St and nearby streets, the Somerville Community Path (Linear Park), Davis Square (Somerville)
Narrator	Uri Kartoun, PhD (DBbun LLC); assessed the route from the point of view of wheelchair, walker and cane users, blind and low-vision people, and people who tire easily. The walker does not have a disability.
Why this route	It links a residential area to a primary care clinic and to the Red Line, which participants from this area would use to reach research visits. The Davis Square area was also suggested for review by the chair of the Somerville Commission for Persons with Disabilities.

Can people complete this journey?

A summary judgment for the trip from Massachusetts Ave at Shea Rd to the clinic in Davis Square and on to the Red Line, by traveler group, based on the items below (day and night).

Traveler	Reach the clinic in Davis Square?	Reach the Red Line from the Holland St side?	Deciding barrier
Wheelchair (manual or power)	With difficulty: path closure detour onto the road; 2 in. gaps; ~2 ft brick sidewalk near Shea Rd	Not from the Holland St entrance (no elevator, no sign). Possible via College Ave elevator (+126 m, 2 crossings) for those who know	Holland St entrance; detour gaps (items 10, 14, 17, 23)
Walker or cane	Yes, with trip hazards: gaps, lifted bricks, potholes in crosswalks	Yes, by stairs or escalator, or via the College Ave elevator	Detour gaps and crosswalk potholes (items 9, 14, 24)
Blind or low vision	With risk: uncontrolled crossing with poor sight lines; worn crosswalk paint; a dark stretch at night	Yes, but no wayfinding to the elevator; strong glare inside (item 27)	Buena Vista Rd crossing (item 11)
People who tire easily	Yes: about 1 km; benches on the Community Path; long signal waits in Davis Square	Yes; the escalator is the low-effort option at Holland St	Signal waits (item 8); distance without seats on side streets

Findings

Severity notes appear in the barrier column; “positive” marks features that worked well. Conf. (confidence): H = seen and recorded on video or photo, or confirmed by official data; M = seen but not measured, or a judgment from one visit. Missing evidence for M items is typically a measurement (width, gap, slope) or a repeat visit.

A. Outbound: Shea Rd to Davis Square

#	Where	Possible barrier or feature	Observation	Most affected	Conf.	Suggested fix
1	Shea Rd (Cambridge)	Root-lifted concrete ground down (positive)	In several places the city has ground down (“shaved”) sidewalk slabs raised by tree roots, removing trip edges. Flat and wide enough for a wheelchair.	-	H	Keep this practice; extend it to brick sections
2	Shea Rd and side streets	Tight spots	Mostly passable, with several tight spots between trees, poles and fences; small bumps and cracks.	Wheelchair, walker	M	Trim plantings; relocate poles where possible
3	Raised crossing with tactile pads	Worn crosswalk paint	Tactile warning pads present (positive), but the crosswalk paint is badly worn and flaking.	Low vision	H	Repaint the crosswalk
4	Crossing before the Linear Park	Steep ramp; ~1 in. lip	Ramp felt steep; small defects; a lip of about 1 in. at the crossing.	Wheelchair, walker	M	Grind or rebuild the lip flush
5	Linear Park / Community Path	Wide path with seating (positive)	Wide, smooth path with benches; brick sections; bollards at entries with passable gaps.	-	H	-
6	Primary care and pediatrics clinic, Davis Square	Accessible entrance (positive)	Level entry from the sidewalk and a push-button door opener at the entrance.	-	H	-
7	Davis Square center	Flat, with curb ramps (positive)	Flat, wide sidewalks; curb ramps at crossings; outdoor seating near cafés.	-	H	-
8	Davis Square signalized crossings	Long waits for the walk signal	Very long waits for the walk signal; many people crossed on red; taxis, SUVs and a fire engine passing.	Slow walkers, people who tire, low vision	H	Review signal timing; shorter pedestrian cycles or leading intervals

B. Return: Davis Square to Shea Rd

#	Where	Possible barrier or feature	Observation	Most affected	Conf.	Suggested fix
9	Crosswalk in Davis Square	Patched asphalt and potholes	Patched asphalt and potholes inside the crosswalk.	Wheelchair, walker, cane	H	Repave the crosswalk

#	Where	Possible barrier or feature	Observation	Most affected	Conf.	Suggested fix
10	Davis station, Holland St entrance	No elevator at this entrance (High)	Stairs and escalators only. The station's street elevator is at the College Ave entrance across the square (confirmed by MBTA facility data: elevators only platform –lobby and lobby–College Ave). MBTA station data also lists this entrance as not wheelchair accessible. A wheelchair user arriving from this side cannot use the nearest entrance; the outdoor detour to the College Ave elevator is about 126 m with 2 street crossings (about 3–4 minutes at a slow pace, plus signal waits). An MBTA project to add an elevator at this entrance is designed but paused pending construction funding. Signage to the accessible entrance was checked on the night walk (item 23).	Wheelchair, scooter, anyone who can't use stairs or escalators	H	Clear signs at the Holland St entrance pointing to the College Ave elevator, with distance; real-time elevator status
11	Crossing at the end of the Linear Park (Buena Vista Rd area)	Dangerous uncontrolled crossing (High)	Yield-to-pedestrian sign only; poor visibility of cars approaching fast from one side.	Wheelchair, slow walkers, low vision	M	Raised crossing, curb extensions or a flashing beacon; improve sight lines
12	Same crossing	Broken concrete at the ramp edge	Broken concrete along the edge of the curb ramp; the ramp is short but steep.	Wheelchair, walker	H	Rebuild the ramp edge
13	Community Path, closed section	Path closed: detour (High, temporary)	"PATH CLOSED" and "DO NOT ENTER" signs for repairs; walkers and wheelchair users are sent onto side streets and the road, shared with bikes.	Everyone; wheelchair users sent onto the road	H	Accessible signed detour on sidewalks with curb ramps; post the detour route at both ends
14	Detour sidewalks	~2 in. gaps between slabs and asphalt (High)	Gaps of about 2 in. between sidewalk slabs and asphalt in two places, near fresh utility markings.	Wheelchair (caster catch), walker, cane	M	Fill the gaps; check after utility work
15	Side-street corners	Steep corners; missing curb ramp	Some corners were steep or lacked a proper curb ramp (a brick corner); cracked slabs.	Wheelchair	M	Add or rebuild curb ramps
16	Back toward Shea Rd	Patch at a ramp; worn paint	An asphalt patch at a curb ramp; worn crosswalk paint at a raised crossing with tactile pads.	Low vision, wheelchair	M	Repair the ramp surface; repaint

#	Where	Possible barrier or feature	Observation	Most affected	Conf.	Suggested fix
17	Near Shea Rd	Very narrow brick sidewalk (High)	A brick sidewalk only about 2 ft wide between a fence and parked cars; overgrown plants at a corner; bricks lifted by tree roots.	Wheelchair, walker, stroller	M	Trim plantings; reset bricks; restore at least 3 ft clear width

C. Night walk: Shea Rd to Davis station (October 24)

#	Where	Possible barrier or feature	Observation	Most affected	Conf.	Suggested fix
18	Shea Rd	Wide, well-lit sidewalk (positive)	Sidewalk more than 10 ft wide in places; good lighting.	-	H	-
19	Shea Rd near Locke St	Dark stretch	A noticeably dark section, partly shaded by trees; hard to see the walking surface. The walker: “there should be another light here.”	Low vision, walker and cane users, anyone at risk of falls	M	Add a street light; trim trees around existing lights
20	Locke St area	Trash barrels on a narrow sidewalk	Trash barrels left on a narrow sidewalk on a Saturday night.	Wheelchair, low vision	H	Barrels back off the walking path after collection
21	Side street	Cones from a house renovation	Cones on the sidewalk at a house entrance under renovation; passable.	Low vision	H	Keep a clear, marked path
22	Community Path and the Buena Vista Rd crossing	Bright LED lighting (positive)	Well lit; surface cracks and the gap reported to the city that morning (about 0.5–2 in.) were clearly visible at night.	-	H	-
23	Davis station, Holland St entrance	No sign pointing to the elevator (High)	No sign at the entrance pointing to the College Ave elevator. A digital screen lists elevator outages at other stations and has a “press for audio” button (positive), but nothing says this entrance has no elevator or where the nearest one is.	Wheelchair, scooter, anyone who can’t use stairs or escalators	H	Static and on-screen sign: “Elevator: College Ave entrance” with distance and direction (see context note on escalator safety)
24	College Ave crossing, Davis Square	Large pothole at the crosswalk	A large pothole and broken edge at the start of the crosswalk by the curb.	Wheelchair, walker, cane	H	Patch and level the crosswalk entry
25	Davis Square plaza	Tree roots lifting bricks; traffic	Bricks lifted by tree roots near the sculptures; a bus went through a red light.	Wheelchair, walker; all pedestrians	M	Reset bricks; enforcement at the crossing
26	College Ave station elevator	Works, but unpleasant and no feedback	The elevator worked. No visible indication after pressing the call button; a strong smell of urine inside.	Anyone who depends on the elevator; people with chemical or smell sensitivity	M	Call-button acknowledgment light; regular cleaning

#	Where	Possible barrier or feature	Observation	Most affected	Conf.	Suggested fix
27	Station lobby	Second elevator (positive); strong glare	A second elevator links the lobby to the platform. New LED lighting is very bright (“almost need sunglasses”).	People with light sensitivity (e.g., migraine, ME/CFS, long COVID), low vision	M	Diffuse or dim the brightest fixtures; avoid direct glare at eye level

Context: escalator safety at Davis station

Two escalator incidents at Davis station were reported in local news in 2026. In February, a rider lost his balance at the bottom of a descending escalator, his clothing became caught in the machinery, and he later died; according to surveillance video reported by NBC10 Boston, more than a dozen riders passed by and the escalator kept running for about 22 minutes until a staff member pressed the emergency stop button. In July, a woman was injured when her clothing became caught at the bottom of an escalator; another rider pressed the stop button (NBC10 Boston, May 12, 2026; WCVB, June 2 and July 31, 2026). The reports do not say which entrance’s escalators were involved. News footage shows red STOP labels at the bottom of the escalators.

The MBTA’s safety reminder states that strollers and wheeled mobility devices are not allowed on escalators and that riders should use the nearest elevator, and that anyone can stop an escalator with the red STOP button at the top and bottom. At the Holland St entrance, where only stairs and escalators are available, no sign shows where the nearest elevator is (items 10 and 23). People who cannot manage stairs, including those with limited mobility, poor balance or fatigue, are left with the escalator or an unsigned walk across the square. Clear elevator signage at this entrance is a low-cost step that follows directly from the MBTA’s own guidance. The time it took for anyone to stop the escalator also matters to riders who fall more easily, such as older adults and people with balance or mobility impairments: staff presence or a help point near the escalators would shorten it.

Checking the AI-assisted analysis

The item list was drafted with AI help from the transcribed narration and the face-blurred frames, then reviewed by the walker. For this report: 19 items were drafted from the two daytime videos; 2 were dropped as not barriers (a temporary toilet, and an item already reported to the city), and items about the walker’s own building were excluded by design. The walker confirmed the six main barriers as drafted; one reading was checked with him and confirmed (“it’s like 2 feet” meant the sidewalk width, not a step); one location detail was corrected (the clinic’s address). Ten night items were drafted and kept. One automated step needed correction: face blurring falsely blurred text on a station sign, which was replaced with an unblurred frame (Figure 9). Station facts (no elevator at Holland St, the elevator at College Ave) were confirmed against MBTA data.

Open-data check

The same route was also screened automatically using only public data: OpenStreetMap, USGS elevation, City of Cambridge open data (curb ramps, sidewalks, obstruction permits,

crashes, service requests), City of Somerville open data (service requests, crashes) and MBTA station facilities. Of the 13 possible barriers above, the data screen predicted 1 (no elevator at the Holland St entrance, from MBTA facility data) and partly indicated 6 (for example, curb ramps with a 1 in. lip recorded in the City of Cambridge inventory, a 14.5% steep stretch in the elevation profile, a mostly brick sidewalk). It missed 6, including the path closure, the detour gaps and the broken ramp edge. Public data is useful for planning a route, but it misses temporary and day-of conditions.

Photo evidence

Frames were taken from the videos. Faces were blurred before review.



Figure 1. Sidewalk slab on Shea Rd ground down where tree roots had lifted it (item 1, positive).



Figure 2. Raised crossing with tactile warning pads and badly worn crosswalk paint (item 3).



Figure 3. Level entry at the primary care and pediatrics clinic in Davis Square (item 6, positive).



Figure 4. Davis station, Holland St entrance: no elevator at this entrance (item 10).



Figure 5. Broken concrete at a curb ramp at the crossing at the end of the Linear Park (item 12).



Figure 6. “Path closed” section of the Community Path, with the detour beginning (item 13).



Figure 7. Gap of about 2 in. between a sidewalk slab and the asphalt on the detour (item 14).

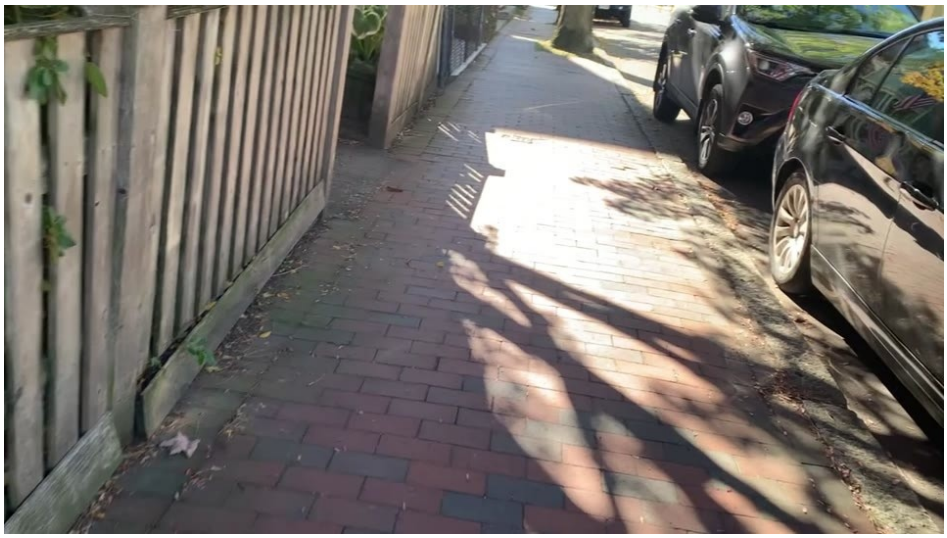


Figure 8. Very narrow brick sidewalk between a fence and parked cars (item 17).

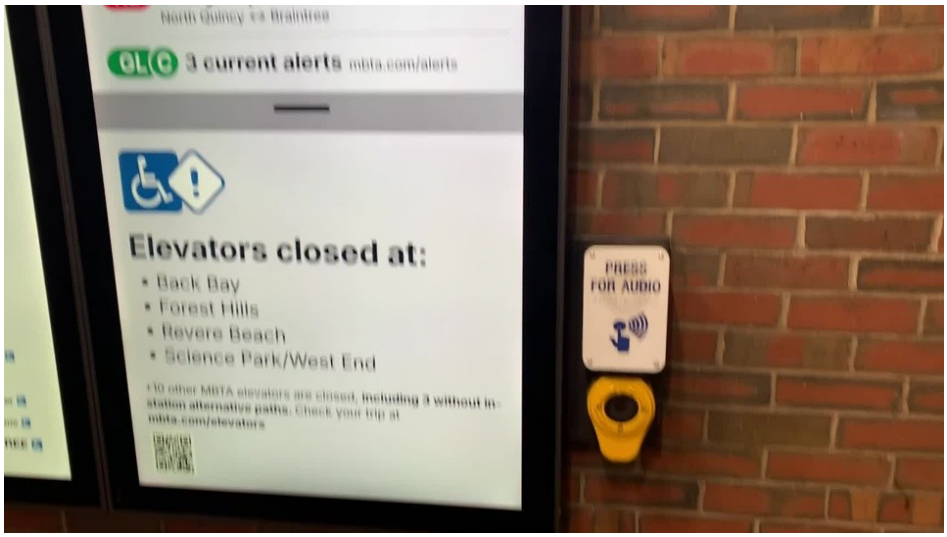


Figure 9. Night: digital screen at the Holland St entrance listing elevator outages at other stations, with a press-for-audio button; no sign points to this station's elevator (item 23).



Figure 10. Night: large pothole and broken edge at the start of a College Ave crosswalk (item 24).

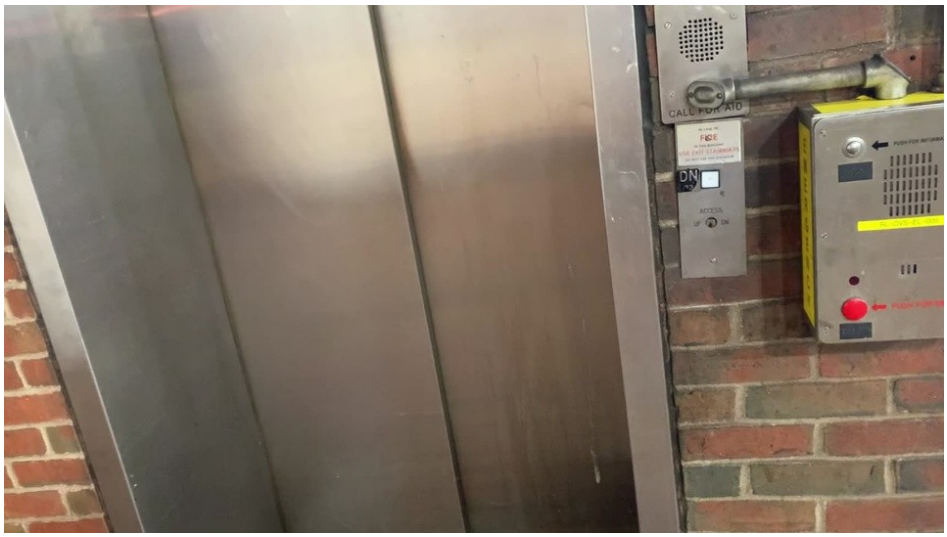


Figure 11. Night: the College Ave elevator at Davis station; it worked, but gave no visible response to the call button (item 26).

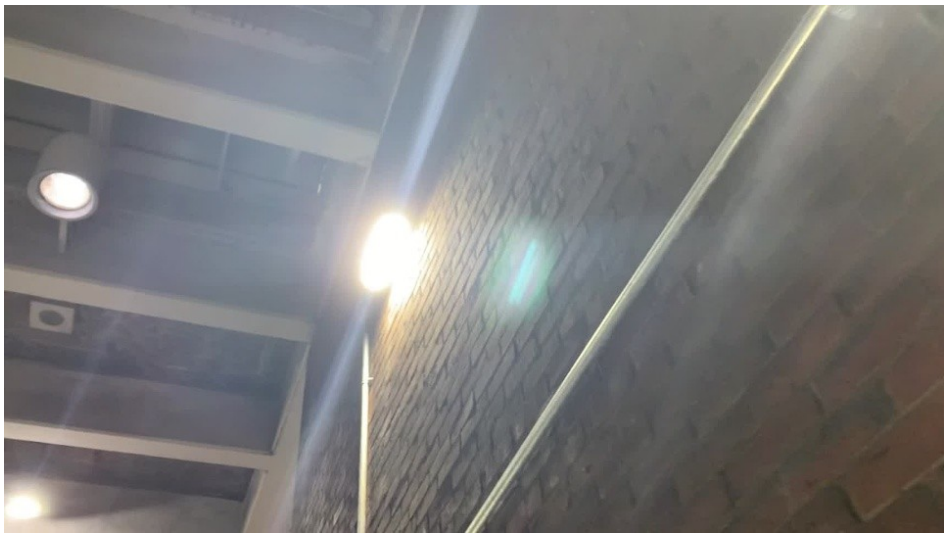


Figure 12. Night: very bright LED lighting inside Davis station (item 27).

How this report was produced

- **Capture:** three narrated smartphone videos made by the author.
- **Local processing on the author's computer:** audio extracted with ffmpeg (imageio-ffmpeg 7.1); narration transcribed with faster-whisper, model medium.en, on a local GPU; one frame sampled every 3 seconds (815 frames); faces blurred with OpenCV 4.14 before any image left the computer.
- **AI review:** the blurred frames and the transcripts were reviewed by Claude (Anthropic), model claude-opus-5-5, which drafted the item list and this report. The author reviewed and confirmed the main findings.
- **Open-data check:** public data listed above, processed with Python (OSMnx, GeoPandas) on the author's computer; MBTA V3 API for station facilities.
- **News sources:** NBC10 Boston, "How did a man die after getting caught in an MBTA escalator?," May 12, 2026; WCVB (Boston), "Vigil held in memory of man who choked to death in tragic MBTA escalator incident," June 2, 2026; and "Woman injured after clothing gets caught in Davis Square Station escalator months after deadly incident," July 31, 2026.

Limitations

- One walker on two days; widths and gap sizes are estimates, not measurements.
- Station signage and the elevator were checked only on the night walk (October 24); elevator status varies from day to day.
- Items are possible barriers, not legal compliance determinations.